



PROGRESS REPORT

East Africa: progress report, September 2025 – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-18 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Compiled 2026-09-18 by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository. Sections run from the region's institutions outwards to what funds them. Each row sets the position at the start of the period against the position at the end, and the Progress column says how it moved. The period runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION ·
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE · CAPACITY AND INCLUSION · FINANCE

Of 54 bodies, instruments and systems on this place's ledger, 38 changed position between 2025-09-01 and 2026-09-18, 10 did not, 6 carry no stated baseline, and 0 are **Not held** at both ends.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 110 sources for this place in the window – 27 in the earlier half (2025-09 to 2026-02), 83 in the later (2026-03 to 2026-09). The earlier half of the window is thin: this is a shorter comparison wearing a longer label, and the movement below rests mostly on the later half.

Progress values. *Movement* – some form of progress, however minor, has been recorded. *Stalled* – a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* – an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a reported position worsened. *Closed* – the programme ended. *No change* – the repository holds a standing position and nothing in the period touched it. *Baseline not held* – there is evidence of movement but no baseline to compare it against. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Movement, slipped*.

Summary of the period

East Africa's ledger opens on a bloc that legislates for its digital single market at the technical level and stalls at the political one: the EAC's payments masterplan, cross-border data rules and monetary-union convergence process all cleared official or technical stages during the period, and none has reached a partner state's own adoption. Against that, the region's physical infrastructure moved without waiting for institutions – Horizon Fiber, DARE1, Seacom's Nairobi–Kampala route and the Paratus Goma–Mombasa corridor all entered or extended service, and a joint bank account now makes a shared communications satellite's funding deadline dated and visible. The [World Bank's own Implementation Status Report on its flagship regional digital-integration project records three years and US\\$162 million against not one governance instrument delivered, alongside an upgraded rating in the same document](#). AI governance runs almost entirely through donor-convened alliances and university councils rather than through the EAC Secretariat, the one track that is not stalling.

What the period also records is the bloc diverging where it has no instrument. Three East African revenue administrations now run [unharmonised electronic-invoicing regimes](#) – [Uganda phased](#), [Kenya simultaneous](#), [Tanzania its own](#), inside a bloc whose payments masterplan assumes the opposite; and South Sudan [imposed a US\\$50 electronic-visa fee on citizens of Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo](#), a charge

levied through a digital channel against a common market protocol that forbids it. Both blocs meanwhile state plainly that [gaps in internet access, digital awareness and technological inclusion continue to threaten the connected regional market they are building](#), without putting a figure to any of them.

Two things did move outside the institutional track. A [regional cybersecurity exercise ran across IGAD member states in late June 2026](#), the first the repository holds, though no scenario or finding from it is published. And Djibouti spent the period positioning itself as the region's hub — its port community system [cited as a global reference at an international maritime seminar](#) and support sought from the ITU and Smart Africa for its [telecoms and artificial-intelligence agenda](#) — on landing points and an incumbent that is still a monopoly rather than on an open market.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
COMESA IDEA programme (Integrated Digital Economy Africa)	US\$2.48bn facility approved June 2024; governance body met twice previously	The Project Steering Committee — a regional economic community, not a member state, holding policy and oversight authority over a dozen countries' digital foundations — met for only the third time since approval, reviewing progress, conducting risk analysis and approving the way forward for 2026, spanning digital foundations, trusted data platforms and applications from social protection to financial services. Separately, COMESA launched its inaugural IDEA Annual Digital Forum in Lusaka on 27 July 2026, which closed with a Strategic Action Plan for harmonised policies, standards and interoperability frameworks; Zambia's host government used the forum to criticise the region's own instrument of choice, arguing partnerships should be judged by outcomes rather than the number of MoUs signed, and Angola's own delegation put its cybersecurity law back at the diagnostic stage at the same forum	MOVEMENT
EAC Cross-Border Payment System Masterplan	Masterplan published March 2025, approved by the Monetary Affairs Committee at its 28th Ordinary Meeting, 14 May 2025; a five-year strategic framework, no implementation body yet	Three Technical Working Groups inaugurated at a first joint meeting in Mombasa, 18-22 August 2026, chaired by the Bank of Uganda with the National Bank of Rwanda as rapporteur, bringing together every partner state's central bank plus the World Bank, GIZ, FSD Network and TradeMark Africa; the TWGs considered a Monitoring and Reporting Framework aligned to G20 cross-border payment targets, a Regional Cooperative Oversight Framework and a Mutual Recognition Framework proposing regional passporting for licensed payment service providers. Separately, the first cross-border instant-payment corridor under the masterplan advanced at a Zanzibar technical meeting, 7-11 July 2026, building on an inaugural Kigali meeting of November 2025 — integrating Tanzania's TIPS with Rwanda's RSwitch, initially person-to-person only, under the EAC's variable-geometry principle (Rwanda and Tanzania only so far), no launch date set	MOVEMENT
EAC Regional Statistics Bureau (for the monetary union)	Did not exist	EALA endorsed a bill creating a Regional Statistics Bureau to serve the planned monetary union; no operational date, budget or staffing is on file since the endorsement	MOVEMENT

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EAC Secretariat recruitment reform (electronic system, moratorium lifted)	Standing moratorium on recruitment to Community organs and institutions	Council of Ministers approved use of an electronic recruitment system and lifted the recruitment moratorium, directing the Secretariat to advertise 69 priority positions across all partner states from FY 2026/2027, with job descriptions validated by partner-state experts	MOVEMENT
EAC single-currency convergence process (Monetary Affairs Committee)	2031 single-currency target standing, convergence criteria not yet tested against the current membership	The 29th MAC meeting kept the 2031 target while minuting that no partner state has attained all four primary convergence criteria; the agreed remedy is a peer-review mechanism for macroeconomic surveillance plus operational frameworks for the EAC Five-Year Development Strategy 2026/27-2030/31. The Central Bank of Congo was absent (apologies) – the bloc's newest and largest member did not attend the meeting that set its own convergence agenda. Governors also called for regulatory harmonisation on AI and digital finance and proposed a joint regional financial-inclusion strategy, both unadopted	STALLED
EAC-IGAD payment integration track	The two blocs setting out a joint path for seamless digital payments across eastern Africa (2025-07)	Governors of the partner-state central banks reaffirmed regional monetary integration and adopted measures to accelerate the regional payment system (2026-07)	MOVEMENT
Electronic invoicing across East African revenue administrations	Three administrations building electronic invoicing separately	Three revenue administrations now run unharmonised regimes: Uganda phased, Kenya simultaneous, Tanzania its own (2026-08)	REGRESSED
IGAD Cross-Border Trade Knowledge-Sharing Network	Did not exist	IGAD member states adopted terms of reference settling the network's membership, governance and knowledge-sharing modalities as a structured platform for market and technical information supporting evidence-based decisions on cross-border agricultural trade, funded through the World Bank-financed Food Systems Resilience Programme	MOVEMENT
Regional education conference on measurable learning outcomes	Did not exist	The second regional education conference brought governments, regional institutions, development partners, researchers and practitioners together on the future of education in the region, with a continental education association pressing for measurable learning outcomes and putting the question as what actually changes on the ground because of the commitments made	MOVEMENT
Regional guidelines on data hosting and the cloud market	Did not exist	At procurement stage: a consultancy invited to develop harmonised regional guidelines for infrastructure sharing, co-location, data hosting and the cloud market	MOVEMENT
EAC currency convertibility and repatriation framework (2014 MoU) and the East African Payment System	MoU on ease of currency convertibility signed May 2014; the East African Payment System, developed the same year, links the Ugandan, Kenyan, Tanzanian and Rwandan RTGS systems	EAC central bank governors conceded that implementation of the convertibility and repatriation framework remains uneven and repatriation arrangements are operationally inefficient, agreeing a Banking & Currency Technical Working Group workshop and a joint MAC sub-committee meeting, both by December 2026, the Bank of Tanzania leading (referencing its own 2019 diagnostic study of cash-handling costs, idle currency stock and settlement gaps). EAPS itself stays lightly used and mostly Kenyan-shilling denominated, with Burundi due to join by December 2026	NO CHANGE
EAC Protocol on Regional Digital Integration	Ratified by Burundi's Senate on a unanimous vote after the communications minister urged adoption; no other partner state's ratification stated (2025-01)	Before partner-state legislatures: Burundi's communications minister told senators in January 2025 that adopting the protocol is crucial to the country's ICT infrastructure (2025-01)	NO CHANGE

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Harmonisation of cybersecurity legal frameworks	Terms of reference issued for a 24-week World Bank-financed (EARDIP) comparative study and recommendations on member states' cybersecurity law; no deliverable stated (2024-05)	A commissioned comparative study and recommendations to harmonise cybersecurity, cybercrime, data protection, digital identity, e-commerce and digital-authentication law across member states	NO CHANGE
IGAD Treaty 2023	BASELINE NOT HELD	Djibouti, Ethiopia, South Sudan, Kenya and Somalia have ratified and deposited, meeting the two-thirds threshold, and the Council of Ministers endorsed the treaty's entry into force in succession to the 1996 agreement, directing the executive secretary to notify member states of the date and register it with the UN and the African Union Commission	BASELINE NOT HELD

Public debate and participation in policymaking

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Independent research on the distributional effects of regional DPI	Scattered academic work with no regional forum	A standing body of critical work: a public dialogue series interrogating digital public infrastructure in East Africa, a feminist analysis of identity, payment and exchange systems across three countries, and field research on identity-required mobile money (2026-03)	MOVEMENT
Regional AI-sovereignty and digital-market discourse	Did not exist	A Rwandan analyst argued East Africa has built an AI application economy and mistaken it for an AI industry — most local startups do not own the intelligence in their products, so engineering, demand and citizens' data generate infrastructure value that accrues elsewhere; he named financing regional GPU infrastructure and hosting African models as the real agenda, while disclosing his own company sells into that answer. The region's own private-sector body, asked separately what blocks a unified EAC digital market, named divergent tax policy, divergent data-protection frameworks, uneven cybersecurity readiness and digital-skills and infrastructure capacity — a diagnosis of rules, not of build, matching the continental-layer finding that governance rather than technology is the constraint	MOVEMENT

The EAC's own organs carried most of the period's institutional movement: a new statistics bureau endorsed, a recruitment moratorium lifted, and the payments masterplan and monetary-union convergence process both moving through technical stages without a partner state yet bound by either. COMESA's IDEA programme moved further than most on this section — a governance body that has now met three times and cut a Strategic Action Plan, even as its own host government at the launch forum publicly criticised the region's habit of signing memoranda rather than delivering outcomes. The one discourse row on this ledger states that diagnosis in general terms: named analysts and the region's own private-sector body both locate the constraint in governance and rules rather than in infrastructure or finance.

Instruments and harmonisation

Data protection

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EAC cross-border Data Protection Authorities coordination body	Did not exist	The EAC created a body letting its eight member-state data-protection authorities share knowledge, align practices and co-investigate, described by an EAC advisor at the ID4Africa 2026 AGM alongside a World Bank session setting out a cross-border 'trust formula' for digital ID and DPI; no charter, meeting record or output is held	MOVEMENT
EAC single digital market – cross-border data-flow and protection rules	Validated at a Dar es Salaam workshop, 25 June 2026	Regional rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection cleared official-level approval on 24 July 2026 and still have to go to the EAC's decision-making organs before any partner state adopts them; no adoption date is published	MOVEMENT
IGAD Regional Health Data Sharing and Protection Policy Framework	In force since October 2021	Standing regional framework governing health-data sharing and protection across IGAD member states; no amendment, review or implementation report is on file for the window	NO CHANGE
Surveillance and spyware use against civil society (East and Southern Africa)	Unwanted Witness report launched in Harare documenting spyware and surveillance tools (Pegasus, FinFisher, IMSI catchers) used against civil society in seven countries (2025-06)	Civil-society organisation Unwanted Witness documented a pattern of surveillance threats – including spyware – used against civil society across East and Southern Africa; no government response or independently verified incident count is held	NO CHANGE

AI

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
COMESA regional AI and digital-inclusion strategy	Did not exist	A regional meeting in Eswatini from 16 September 2026, under the World Bank-funded IDEA programme, validated a draft study on artificial intelligence and emerging technologies with member states, the African Union and the World Bank, as the first phase before a regional AI strategy, model policy guidelines and a model regulatory framework are developed. Neither the draft study nor a strategy text is published	MOVEMENT
EAC Regional AI Policy Roadmap / AI-sovereignty bloc	Did not exist	The 4th EAC Regional Science, Technology and Innovation Conference in Kigali explored a regional AI Policy Roadmap across the eight-member bloc, framed by Rwanda's ICT minister around East Africa 'leading as a unified bloc' so that data 'stays in our hands' and AI-generated value accrues to East Africans; no roadmap text, timetable or adoption route is published	MOVEMENT

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Horn of Africa regional artificial-intelligence framework	Did not exist	The regional development authority opened a two-day consultation in Addis Ababa on 4 and 5 September 2026 to develop a common regional framework and strategy for artificial intelligence. Its executive secretary put data sovereignty and accountability at the centre, arguing that territorial sovereignty in the digital era increasingly depends on states' ability to control, manage and responsibly use their own data, and set three priorities: directing investment where socioeconomic impact is greatest, closing gaps in digital infrastructure, policy and human skills, and building regional synergies through policy harmonisation and cross-border initiatives. He insisted the framework be owned by member states rather than treated as a secretariat project; the consultation is examining member states' differing readiness	MOVEMENT
East African AI Policy Outlook Report (CIPIT)	Kenya with an AI strategy for 2025-2030, Tanzania carrying AI inside its ICT policy and Uganda with no dedicated AI policy (2025-06)	CIPIT's four-country baseline, deliberately without a ranking, splits its sample two ways: Kenya and Rwanda have adopted national AI instruments and are building coordination around them, while Tanzania and Uganda are still developing strategies off existing digital and data-protection frameworks	NO CHANGE
IGAD Artificial Intelligence Centre of Excellence	BASELINE NOT HELD	The IGAD Council of Ministers endorsed establishing an AI centre of excellence in principle at its 74th extraordinary session and asked member states to bid to host it at the next ordinary session; no host, budget or mandate is set	BASELINE NOT HELD
Regional higher-education quality assurance under AI	BASELINE NOT HELD	The 15th annual East African higher education quality assurance forum met in Kigali on 7 September 2026, bringing together higher education regulators and institutions from across the region to consider whether today's degrees prepare graduates for tomorrow's labour market; the host country's education minister told it the region must rethink how it defines and assures quality as artificial intelligence changes how knowledge is produced, taught and applied.	BASELINE NOT HELD

Two data-protection tracks moved in different directions: the EAC's cross-border DPA coordination body and its single-digital-market data rules both advanced procedurally, while the one long-standing instrument on this section – IGAD's 2021 health-data framework – recorded no change, and a civil-society report on surveillance and spyware use against the region's own civil society carries no government response to weigh against it. AI instruments are earlier-stage across the board: COMESA and the EAC are each drafting a regional AI framework in parallel, neither yet a text, and CIPIT's own four-country baseline finds only Kenya and Rwanda with adopted national AI instruments to build on.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
AfPIF 2026 (Kigali) inland-connectivity agenda	Did not exist (this edition)	Africa's peering forum put landlocked markets at the centre of its 2026 edition, framed around inland East and Central African markets with no direct access to submarine cable landing stations, and what stronger interconnection, carrier-neutral data centres and local content delivery can do about their cost and resilience	MOVEMENT

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
DARE1 subsea cable extension (Djibouti Telecom)	DARE1 in service connecting Djibouti to earlier landing points	Djibouti Telecom extended the DARE1 subsea cable to connect East and Southern Africa, adding a route from Kenya to South Africa of about 3,200 to 3,500 km on a system operational since 2021 at 36 Tbps; commercial terms are not stated	MOVEMENT
Djibouti as a regional connectivity and digital hub	A landing-point economy on the incumbent operator's monopoly	Positioned as a regional hub: the port community system cited as a global reference in April 2026, the digital vision put to the world summit in July, and partnerships sought with the ITU and Smart Africa for telecoms and artificial intelligence (2026-07)	MOVEMENT
Horizon Fiber cross-border initiative (Ethio telecom-Djibouti Telecom-Sudatel)	Did not exist	Ethio telecom, Djibouti Telecom and Sudatel Group signed a binding tripartite agreement establishing the Horizon Fiber cross-border connectivity initiative, linking Ethiopia, Djibouti and Sudan; no route capacity, cost or in-service date is stated in any of the signing announcements	MOVEMENT
Paratus Goma-Mombasa fibre highway (G2M)	Route launched February 2026	Paratus's protected fibre corridor runs about 2,000km from Goma to Mombasa, connecting Kigali, Kampala and Nairobi as part of a network the company states spans 16 African countries; showcased alongside Starlink-powered services at Paratus Rwanda's first-anniversary event during AfPIF 2026	MOVEMENT
Seacom East Africa backbone (Nairobi-Kampala route, Seacom 2.0)	Seacom 2.0, a 48-fibre-pair Indian Ocean Basin subsea system engineered for low-latency AI workloads, announced September 2025	Seacom deployed a new high-capacity terrestrial route between Nairobi and Kampala to strengthen its East Africa digital backbone, positioned as extending the reach of the wider Seacom 2.0 subsea system toward landlocked East African markets	MOVEMENT

Data Storage

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
East African data-centre market	BASELINE NOT HELD	Assessed in a regional market brief prepared for donor and investment-facility partners (2025-05)	BASELINE NOT HELD

Cybersecurity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
IGAD regional cybersecurity exercise	BASELINE NOT HELD	Run across the bloc, with one national computer emergency response team singled out for its performance (2026-07)	BASELINE NOT HELD

Data Exchange

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Regional Electronic Cargo Tracking System (RECTS)	BASELINE NOT HELD	The platform lets East African tax authorities track transit goods in real time by GPS and electronic seals; Kenya's revenue authority opened it to private seal vendors, which shippers welcomed as ending seal shortages behind delays at Mombasa, where transit cargo is more than 30 per cent of throughput. No vendor list or start date is published	BASELINE NOT HELD

Digital Identity and CRVS

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EAC labour mobility and electronic visa charges	Free movement within the bloc, electronic visa portals in use	A USD 50 fee imposed on citizens of Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo through the electronic visa portal (2026-07)	REGRESSED
EAC travel-document and passport harmonisation (NCIP national-ID travel, EAC e-Passport)	Since January 2014, national identity cards of Uganda, Rwanda and Kenya have been recognised as a valid travel document alongside national and EAC passports under the Northern Corridor Integration Projects, allowing citizens to cross the three borders and remain up to six months without further documentation	Somalia, a full EAC member since March 2024, was cleared to adopt and print the EAC e-Passport in February 2026. South Sudan's civil-registry directorate said in July 2026 it will introduce the EAC passport under the Community agreement alongside a new ten-year national booklet – an announced intention requiring the passport act to be amended and approval from the Council of Ministers and the Transitional National Legislative Assembly, with no legislative timetable given	MOVEMENT
Mutual recognition of national identity documents	Kenya, Rwanda and Uganda already recognised each other's national IDs as travel documents; a study proposed a four-milestone interoperability path over seven or more years, not yet taken up by the EAC (2018-08)	A 2018 study for the regional bloc set out a four-milestone architecture for regional identity interoperability, recording that South Sudan had issued more than a million identity cards by then (2018-08)	NO CHANGE

Digital Payments and Fintech

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
COMESA Digital Retail Payments Platform	Did not exist	The 21-nation COMESA bloc launched a digital payment system to settle trade in local currencies rather than in US dollars; adoption figures and participating banks are not stated	MOVEMENT
SCRYPT stablecoin settlement network (four East African markets)	Did not exist	SCRYPT expanded its stablecoin settlement network across four East African markets, including Uganda; scale, volume and regulatory basis are not stated in the report	MOVEMENT
Vodacom/Safaricom M-PESA regional expansion	Vodacom Group took a controlling stake in Safaricom, reported 2025	Vodacom intensified its East Africa strategy around its 55% Safaricom stake and M-PESA, targeting 130 million financial-services customers by 2030; separately Vodacom Tanzania and Thunes rolled out M-PESA links extending to Uganda and China	MOVEMENT
State of Inclusive Instant Payment Systems census	Published annually	Published for a fourth year as the continent's census of instant payment systems, the payments layer of digital public infrastructure (2025-11)	NO CHANGE

Sectoral management information systems

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
IMPULSE study – newborn-data electronic health information systems	Under way in the Central African Republic, Ethiopia, Tanzania and Uganda, having contributed to version 2.0 of the newborn measurement tools; no findings on electronic systems published (2024-07)	The IMPULSE study examined the functionalities of electronic routine health information systems related to newborn data across Uganda, Ethiopia, Tanzania and the Central African Republic; findings are the study's own and no follow-up policy response is on file	MOVEMENT

Other GovTech and e-Gov

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EU-EAC DEEP programme (digital-trade and DPI technical-assistance tenders)	GIZ tendered technical assistance for digital public infrastructure projects in the EAC, 31 July 2026	Under the EU-EAC DEEP programme, GIZ separately tendered an e-commerce business-development consultancy (7 August) and a Tanzania/Uganda/Kenya-facing DPI consulting engagement (5 August); each is a procurement notice rather than a project, so the programme is at the pipeline-preparation stage across digital ID, data exchange, payments and e-government, with no budget, duration or award stated for any of the three tenders	MOVEMENT
GovTech Maturity Index 2025 – East African benchmarking (World Bank)	Tanzania and Uganda in Group A and Kenya, Rwanda and Ethiopia in Group B on the 2022 edition (2023-03)	The World Bank's 2025 GovTech Maturity Index placed Tanzania in Group A ('Extensive') alongside Kenya, Rwanda, Uganda and Egypt, the index now weighting interoperability and adoption over launched portals – working as peer pressure across East Africa's digital states	MOVEMENT Kenya and Rwanda joined Group A

National statistics

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EAC/IGAD statistical harmonisation (SDMX)	EAC Secretariat convened a technical working session to harmonise SDMX data-structure definitions for CPI and merchandise-trade statistics, 31 July 2026	IGAD separately convened a capacity-building programme to strengthen regional statistical systems through SDMX; both harmonisation strands aim at consumer-price and trade statistics being comparable and exchangeable across member states, with no completion date or adoption instrument stated for either	MOVEMENT
EACO Regional Communications Sector Statistics Report	A 2023 edition launched in June 2024 reporting 199.7 million mobile subscribers, 122.3 million internet subscriptions and 128.7 million mobile-money subscriptions, compiled by the secretariat from its databank (2024-06)	EACO's first regulator-submitted dataset covering all seven member states records 334.69 million active mobile subscriptions in 2025 and mobile money value up 19.6% across the five reporting countries; DRC and South Sudan reported no transaction values at all, and every mobile-money figure is presented in US dollars though EACO's own stated methodology is local currency, with no exchange rate, conversion date or basis given	MOVEMENT

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
User satisfaction survey on regional statistics	Did not exist	The community secretariat opened an online user satisfaction survey on regional statistics on 3 September 2026, run under an eastern Africa regional statistics programme for results. It asks users across the partner states about the quality, relevance, reliability, timeliness, accessibility and usefulness of regional statistics and about barriers to access, and is addressed to national statistics offices, central banks, regional bodies, the private sector, academia, development partners, civil society, media and independent researchers; the findings are to guide statistical products and dissemination	MOVEMENT

Use of satellite data

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
East African regional communications satellite (NCIP feasibility study)	East African countries, including Uganda, announced plans to launch a regional satellite under the Northern Corridor Integration Projects (NCIP), reported 4 May 2026	Uganda, Kenya, Rwanda and South Sudan opened a dedicated 'East African Development Bank-NCIP' account at Standard Chartered Bank Uganda to fund a feasibility study for a jointly owned regional communications satellite, with partner states given until 30 September 2026 to deposit their contributions; the roadmap and budget are approved at the April 2026 Nairobi NCIP meeting, but neither the study's cost nor per-country contributions is disclosed, so whether the deadline is demanding or trivial is unestablished	MOVEMENT

Physical connectivity is where the region's own operators moved fastest and furthest ahead of any institution: Horizon Fiber, the DARE1 extension, Seacom's backbone and the Paratus Goma–Mombasa corridor all entered or extended service without waiting on a regional body, and AfPIF's 2026 edition made the resulting gap — landlocked markets with no direct cable-landing access — its own agenda. Travel-document harmonisation is the one system with a decade of running record behind it, the Northern Corridor states' 2014 national-ID arrangement now extending to Somalia and, on paper, South Sudan. Payments infrastructure split by owner: private rails (M-PESA, SCRYPT) expanded on their own commercial logic, while COMESA's own platform is the one publicly owned system to enter service, settling trade in local currencies across 21 states. The satellite study's joint account is the clearest institutional mechanism on this section precisely because it is the least usual one — a dated, public funding deadline rather than a communiqué.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
EAC AI Alliance and AI-in-education harmonisation	EAC AI Alliance launched March 2026 with an invitation to universities to join a regional network	In April 2026 partner states agreed to work toward harmonising AI-related curricula, developing regional certification and accreditation frameworks, and strengthening TVET for an AI-driven economy. On 17 September 2026 the East African Science and Technology Commission and the German state of Hessen launched a cooperation through the alliance, linking the region's AI base to Hessen for skills development, innovation and business, with no sum, instrument or duration stated	MOVEMENT

Digital divides

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Regional digital access gap	Significant infrastructure gaps, rural areas underserved and landlocked states paying most, with 2 GB of data costing USD4.64 in Kenya and USD21.06 in South Sudan on 2021 figures (2024-09)	Both regional bodies state that gaps in internet access, digital awareness and technological inclusion continue to threaten a connected regional market (2026-05)	NO CHANGE

The AI-in-education workstream is the ledger's clearest case of an East African instrument advancing on schedule, and it is routed around the Secretariat rather than through it — a donor-convened alliance and a university council carrying curriculum harmonisation and an accountability framework to 2028, with the EAC's own organs holding only the monitoring role.

Finance

New investments

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-18	PROGRESS
Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project (EARDIP, World Bank)	World Bank project approved 18 May 2023 (P176181), a second phase (SOP-II, P180931) approved December 2023	Three years and US\$162 million into the region's flagship digital-integration project, the Implementation Status Report records that not one of the governance instruments it was meant to produce exists. Delivered: a Kenya-South Sudan connectivity MoU and an IGAD information-sharing framework. Not delivered: South Sudan's CSIRT, cloud guidelines in either state, any e-commerce strategy, an EAC cross-border data-transfer mechanism, and US\$0 of private investment mobilised — against which the World Bank's own rating was upgraded in the same report. All eight partner states had reaffirmed their commitment to inclusive regional data-governance frameworks at the project's third steering committee in Nairobi a month before that report	STALLED
Entrepreneurship and Innovation Development Project (AfDB with IGAD)	Did not exist	About US\$3.26m from the transition support mechanism across Sudan, South Sudan and Djibouti, Sudan's component run through the University of Khartoum's entrepreneurship incubator	MOVEMENT
East Africa data-centre and connectivity financing (EIB/AXIAN, RMB/Wingu Africa)	Rand Merchant Bank provided Wingu Africa USD 60 million for data-centre and connectivity build-out in Ethiopia, Djibouti and Tanzania, with a second Tanzania facility under construction (2025-06)	Rand Merchant Bank backed a Wingu Africa data-centre expansion across Ethiopia, Djibouti and Tanzania; the European Investment Bank granted AXIAN Telecom financing for 4G/5G rollout reaching Tanzania (and Madagascar); AXIAN separately pledged 4G expansion investment under the Partner2Connect initiative reaching Tanzania (and Comoros and Madagascar). Deal values and completion dates for the XEA-relevant legs specifically are not broken out in the reports held	NO CHANGE

The region's flagship financing instrument is also its clearest stalled position: EARDIP's own Implementation Status Report, three years and US\$162 million in, lists a CSIRT, cloud guidelines, an e-commerce strategy and a cross-border data-transfer mechanism as not delivered, against a rating upgrade recorded in the same document. Private

and development-bank financing for data centres and mobile connectivity continued in parallel, but the deals held here are regional in name more than in structure — each names Tanzania alongside markets outside XEA's own remit, so the East African share of the money is not separable from the total stated.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	2026-09-18
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/XEA/XEA-progress-2026-09-18.pdf
FEEDBACK	info@data-landscapers.io
LICENCE	CC BY 4.0